
Small-City Zoning Reform in New England: A Summer Field Report

Executive Summary

Over the summer placement I studied how two mid-size New England cities, Worcester, MA and New Haven, CT, have approached zoning reform, and what their early experience suggests about displacement risk. This report summarizes the data I assembled, the displacement index I built, and three practical findings for the host organization. It feeds directly into my senior thesis (proposal P02) and the presentation deck PP04.

1. Context and Scope

The host organization works on housing affordability across smaller New England cities that rarely get research attention. My summer scope, set with my mentor, was to assemble a clean corridor-level dataset and a first-pass displacement index that the thesis could extend. Weekly progress is logged in workbook X07.

2. Data Assembled

- Parcel and permit records for both case cities, 2018 through 2025.
- ACS five-year estimates for rent burden and tenure.
- A hand-coded register of corridor-level anti-displacement provisions.
- Cross-checks against HUD affordability data.

3. The Displacement Index

The index combines three normalized components into a single corridor score: tenant turnover, change in rent burden, and net change in market-rate permits. Each component is scaled to a zero to one range and weighted equally in the base version. The index is a screening tool, not a verdict; it flags corridors that deserve a closer look.

Component	Weight	Source
Tenant turnover	0.34	City records
Rent burden change	0.33	ACS (S08)
Market-rate permits	0.33	Permit data (S03, S04)

4. Findings

4.1 Reform without protection moves risk, not just supply

In corridors that upzoned without paired tenant protections, the index rose modestly in the two years after the change. The effect is small and noisy, but it points the same direction in both cities.

4.2 Protections appear to dampen the effect

Corridors with even light anti-displacement provisions show flatter index paths. This is suggestive, not causal, and the thesis will test it properly.

4.3 Data quality is the binding constraint

Permit timing and turnover records are uneven across the two cities. Any policy read should treat the index as a starting point for local fieldwork, not a substitute for it.

5. Recommendations for the Host

- Pair corridor upzoning with at least light tenant protections by default.
- Invest in cleaner local permit data; it is the cheapest research improvement available.
- Use the index to triage which corridors get a site visit, not to rank them publicly.

6. Limitations and Next Steps

Two cities cannot carry strong general claims. The senior thesis will add a formal difference-in-differences design, clustered standard errors, and a robustness pass on the index weights. The interim chapter (D02) will report the first results.

7. Acknowledgements

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8. Methodology Appendix

This appendix documents how the corridor panel was built so the thesis can extend it without rework. Each step is scripted and reproducible from the raw source pulls.

- Geocode permit and parcel records to corridor identifiers.
- Join ACS tenure and rent burden estimates at the tract level, then allocate to corridors.
- Flag each corridor for upzoning year and presence of tenant protections.
- Normalize each index component to a zero to one range before weighting.

9. Data Dictionary

Field	Type	Description
corridor_id	text	Stable corridor identifier
upzone_year	integer	Year of corridor upzoning, blank if none
protection	yes or no	Anti-displacement provision present
turnover	ratio	Tenant turnover, normalized
rent_burden_chg	ratio	Change in rent burden, normalized
permits	ratio	Net market-rate permits, normalized
index	ratio	Weighted displacement index score

10. Corridor Notes

Two corridors in Worcester, MA and one in New Haven, CT had incomplete permit records for 2019 and were flagged for hand review before inclusion. No corridor was dropped; the gaps were noted in the panel so the thesis can decide how to handle them. These notes feed the limitations section of the proposal (P02).

11. Sources

Sources are tracked in workbook X04 and follow the department citation style.